

areas. It has varied geographical conditions. Two-three districts are entirely in the plains while nine are entirely in the hills. We want industry to reach districts such as Pauri, Chamoli and Almora as well. We are working to build industrial parks there. There are several small entrepreneurs and people who want to start enterprises. The 'Our One District-Two Products' scheme is already running.

Q: Every state is competing for land and skilled manpower. Does Uttarakhand have enough land for investors and industry?

A: Uttarakhand's situation is very different from other states. We do not have very large land banks, but what we have is adequate for industrial requirements. Land is available in Haridwar and Dehradun. And we have a substantial land bank in Udham Singh Nagar. Whoever wants to set up industry or invest will be provided land as well as other facilities.

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“We want farmers to become entrepreneurs of the rural economy. Through various missions, we are connecting mountain agriculture with the new economy”

Q: What is your message to the younger generation about their role in India's development?

A: When we talk about youth, and especially Gen Z, I call them the Indian Generation. At one point, we both were Gen Z. Those who fought for India's independence—freedom fighters like Chandrashekhar Azad, Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Ram Prasad Bismil—were all Gen Z. Today's generation is aware, wise and connected to the world. The most important thing is the connectivity we have built—call it the communication revolution or the IT revolution. Young people observe the changing environment across the world. Naturally, they feel these changes should happen here too. They have expectations and we must listen to them. Just as the world has moved forward, we must also move forward. That is what our young people want.

The Prime Minister rightly said that these children are ours and the government belongs to them too. We

are doing our part accordingly. In Uttarakhand, youth and water are our greatest priorities. They should serve the state.

One major issue was paper leaks and cheating. I started work as chief minister on July 4, 2021, and from the very first day resolved that if there was any wrongdoing or irregularity in an examination or recruitment process, or if the selection process was not transparent, we would not hide it.

Some cases were continuing from before. We acted on them, and 100 people from cheating mafias had to go to jail during our government's tenure.

In these five years, we have made 34,000 new recruitments. Not a single case of corruption has come up in any of them. Our selections are conducted in a completely transparent manner.

A number of candidates and their parents have met and thanked us. They told us their sons and daughters had been working hard and writing examinations earlier too but were not being selected. In these years, some of those same candidates were selected in four-five examinations. Many came from humble families.

You may think 34,000 is a small figure, but for our state, it is very large. Ever since Uttarakhand was formed by the then Prime Minister Atal Behari Vajpayee, the total number of appointments are 50,000. Of these, 16,000 were made in 21 years, while in just five years, we recruited 34,000. The hiring is still ongoing.

We have also built a start-up ecosystem. When I came to power, there were 700 start-ups in the state. Today, we have nearly 2,000. Many people are opening homestays and small hotels, working in agriculture and horticulture, and establishing small enterprises.

Q: How are you balancing industrialisation with agriculture and rural entrepreneurship?

A: We want farmers to become entrepreneurs of the rural economy. Through various missions—for fruits like apples and kiwis to millets, natural farming, dairy production, fisheries, beekeeping and medicinal plants—we are connecting mountain agriculture with the new economy.

Our focus is not only on production but on the entire value chain—processing, packaging, branding and marketing—so that farmers receive greater returns. Women's participation is equally important. We are working to empower women through various steps, including the Lakhpati Didi initiative.

Q: How do you balance development with environmental concerns in a Himalayan state?